Bank Veto Message

President Andrew Jackson · July 10, 1832

Source: Andrew Jackson, Veto Message Regarding the Bank of the United States (July 10, 1832), text via the Avalon Project, Yale Law School. Public domain.

Henry Clay tried to make the Second Bank of the United States an issue in the 1832 election by pushing an early recharter through Congress. Jackson — who saw the Bank as a corrupt tool of eastern elites — vetoed the bill and explained his reasoning in a fiery message aimed less at Congress than at ordinary voters. The Bank War defined Jacksonian Democracy and reshaped the American party system.

Connect: Jackson's fight with the Bank echoes Jefferson's opposition to Hamilton's Bank from Class 6. What's the same? What's different?

Key Passages

On equal protection of the laws

> It is to be regretted that the rich and powerful too often bend the acts of government to their selfish purposes. … when the laws undertake to add to these natural and just advantages artificial distinctions, to grant titles, gratuities, and exclusive privileges, to make the rich richer and the potent more powerful, the humble members of society-the farmers, mechanics, and laborers-who have neither the time nor the means of securing like favors to themselves, have a right to complain of the injustice of their Government.

On monopoly

> Many of our rich men have not been content with equal protection and equal benefits, but have besought us to make them richer by act of Congress. … If we can not at once, in justice to interests vested under improvident legislation, make our Government what it ought to be, we can at least take a stand against all new grants of monopolies and exclusive privileges

On foreign stockholders

> Should its influence become concentered, as it may under the operation of such an act as this, in the hands of a self-elected directory whose interests are identified with those of the foreign stockholders, will there not be cause to tremble for the purity of our elections in peace and for the independence of our country in war?

HIPP Analysis

Model answers fill the first three rows. Use them to explain the author's Purpose in the last row.

HIPP Element	Your Analysis
Historical Situation *What was happening when this was written?*	The Bank War (1832): Henry Clay and Nicholas Biddle pushed an early recharter of the Second Bank of the United States through Congress to make it an issue in the 1832 election.
Intended Audience *Who was the source written for?*	Congress, but mainly ordinary voters (farmers, workers, and Western and Southern voters) in the 1832 election.

HIPP Element	Your Analysis
Point of View *Whose perspective? Whose is missing?*	President Andrew Jackson, a self-styled champion of the 'common man' who distrusted banks, paper money, and Eastern financial elites.
Purpose *What did the author want to accomplish?*	

Analysis Prompts

1. SAQ practice: Provide ONE example of how Jackson framed the Bank as an enemy of ordinary Americans.
2. How does Jackson's populist rhetoric here anticipate later movements (Populists, Progressives, New Deal)?
3. Whose interests did Jackson NOT speak for in this message?